

Pook's Tangled Paths

The emerald isles of the Celts roll green and misty between a silver sea and soft grey skies, dotted with thatched roundhouses, ancient oak groves, and rings of humming standing stones. Mist drifts over still lochs, and across it, just out of sight, lies the Land of Youth where no one grows old. The isles are full of gentle wonders: a playful shapeshifting faerie, an old, bright salmon, a shy selkie of the loch, and four children long ago turned into singing swans. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is full of ideas, listens kindly, and keeps a promise. The grandest deeds are done with imagination and courage and a kind heart, and even a fearsome-seeming stranger, met with a friendly word, often turns out lonelier than it is unkind.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

The May fair was only a day away, and the whole village had been baking and weaving and tuning their fiddles for it. But that morning a worried farmer came running to the Roundhouse: the winding paths of the Whispering Oak Grove had gone all tangled, looped over and round with soft ribbons of mist, and not a soul could find the way through to the fair.

Everyone knew at once who had done it. Pook the Puca, a playful faerie who can slip from shape to shape as easily as you change your mind, had been at his games. He meant no harm by it. To Pook, a tangled path is simply the best sort of riddle, and he had quite forgotten that the village folk would mind.

Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver called the two of you to her side by the warm hearth. "You have heads full of ideas and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more in the grove than the strongest arm. Will you go and untangle the paths, and win our Pook over with a friendly word, so he sets them right himself?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a ball of bright red wool, a honey oatcake still warm from the hearth, and a small sprig of oak leaves for luck. "Remember," she said, "here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."



What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Imagination, Courage, or Kindness?

Stop 1 The Tangled Grove

You stepped in under the great oaks, and at once the grove began to play its trick. The paths looped and twisted and doubled back, and every leafy turning looked exactly like the last. You walked and walked with great care, and somehow you always came round again to the very same gnarled old oak you had started from.

A traveller without a plan could wander these paths until the moon came up and still be no closer to the fair.



How will you keep from getting lost? You carry a ball of red wool. What might you do with it? Could you tie one end at the start and let it trail behind you?

So you knotted the red wool tight around a low branch at the entrance, and let it unspool gently behind you as you went. Now every step was a step you could undo, and the looping grove could not trap a hero who carried a thread. Before long you found the one path that led on, deeper into the whispering wood.

Stop 2 Pook's Three Doors

The trees drew back and the path opened into a quiet green clearing. There, woven from living oak branches and hung with soft moss, stood three tall archway doors, side by side. Only one of them led onward. The other two, you felt sure, would loop you straight back the way you had come.

With a rustle of leaves, Pook himself popped up: a small furry shape with bright, mischievous eyes and a grin that could not sit still. He loved nothing better than a good clue, and he gave you three of them, sing-song and teasing:

★ *"The left door loves the morning sun, but it sends you back where you begun. The middle door is mossy and old, and it keeps a fib for every tale it told. The right door is quiet and small and true, and that is the door that will see you through."*

★ *Which door is the true one? Will you read his clues again, slowly, and puzzle them out together? Pook seems willing to drop a hint if you ask kindly. What do you try?*

When you chose the right-hand door, it swung wide on a happy creak, and a warm breeze of grove-smell came through. Pook laughed and turned a somersault clean over a fern, delighted that you had played his game so well. You stepped through into the deep heart of the wood.

Stop 3 Winning Pook Over

Deeper in the grove, where the light fell soft and green, you found Pook again. But he was not laughing now. He sat hunched on a toadstool with his knees pulled up to his chin, looking very small, watching his own toes.

He had made the whole grove into a glorious game, and only now, in the quiet, had it dawned on him that the village folk were sad and that the fair might not happen. He felt a little bit sorry, and he did not quite know how to say so.

★ *This was never a fight. What kindness could you show him? You have a honey oatcake to share. You could sit down beside him on the toadstool. You could tell him there is room for him at the fair too. What do you do?*

When you sat beside him and broke the honey oatcake in two and shared it, Pook's bright eyes went soft and warm. "You are not cross with me?" he whispered, hardly able to believe it. "Then I will set it all right, every last tangle, I promise."

The Paths Run True

Pook sprang up onto his furry feet and clapped his paws three times. All across the Whispering Oak Grove, the ribbons of mist came loose and unwound and drifted away on the breeze, and the winding paths fell straight and true, every one of them, just as they should be.

And this time Pook did not vanish into the leaves. He skipped along at your side, leading the way out, prouder of helping than he had ever been of any trick. Down in the village the folk cheered as the paths opened before them, and the May fair began in a swirl of ribbons and fiddle music and dancing on the green.

High above the emerald isles, Danu the Kind looked down through the parting mist and smiled. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your courage, with your kindness,

and with all your bright ideas. Well done, heroes of the Emerald Isles.

Pook's Tangled Paths: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle tale: the only "foe" is a lonely faerie who simply wants a friend, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Roundhouse.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for the red wool, a small cake or token for the honey oatcake, and a leaf or twig for the sprig of oak. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**.

When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Kindness together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In this grove, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll

Twist of Fate

1	Pook the Puca pops up and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze through the oaks, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Salmon of Wisdom blows a lucky bubble. All is well.
5	A sprig of oak for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

Pook the Puca is the "foe", but he is no villain. He is a playful faerie who made a game of the paths and then felt sorry for the trouble it caused. The tale is won not by beating him but by befriending him: sharing the honey oatcake, sitting beside him, telling him there is a place for him at the fair. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. Befriended, Pook gladly untangles every path himself. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

Pook's Tangled Paths: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Tangled Grove (Easy)

The challenge. The winding paths of the Whispering Oak Grove loop and double back, and the players keep arriving at the same old oak. They must find a way through without getting hopelessly lost.

Intended solution. This is an Imagination and Spatial moment. The good, kind move is to use the **ball of red wool**: tie one end at the entrance and unspool it as you go, so you can always retrace your steps and never walk the same wrong loop twice. Marking each turning, or following the thread back to try a new path, works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, let the red wool tug gently towards the true path, or have a friendly robin hop ahead from branch to branch. Getting through with a little help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 2: Pook's Three Doors (Normal)

The challenge. Pook has grown three mossy archway doors of oak branches. Only one leads onward; the other two loop the players back. They must read his playful clues and choose the true door.

The clues. Read them aloud: *"The left door loves the morning sun, but it sends you back where you begun. The middle door is mossy and old, and it keeps a fib for every tale it told. The right door is quiet and small and true, and that is the door that will see you through."* The **right-hand door** is the way on: the left clue says plainly that it sends you back, the middle clue admits it tells fibs, and the right clue is the only one that calls itself true.

Intended solution. This is a Logic and Observation moment. Let the children talk the clues through together and listen for the door that says it is true while the others give themselves away. A thoughtful guess is welcome too.

Fallback. If they are stuck, read the clues again slowly, one door at a time, or let Pook lean in and whisper, "Listen to which door tells the truth." A door chosen bravely still creaks open onto the right path.

Stop 3: Winning Pook Over (Normal, then no roll)

The challenge. The players find Pook the Puca hunched on a toadstool, no longer laughing. He looks small and sorry. The children may wonder how to make things right.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Courage moment. Pook is simply a little ashamed and unsure how to say sorry. Any genuine kindness works: sharing the **honey oatcake**, sitting down beside him, telling him there is room for him at the May fair, saying that everyone makes a muddle sometimes. When the children are kind, Pook brightens and promises to set every path right himself.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or want to scold him, have Pook sniffle and ask, very quietly, "Are you cross with me too?" A single kind word melts him. The moment the players offer any friendly gesture at all, he hops up and undoes the whole tangle.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When Pook claps his paws, the ribbons of mist unwind, the paths of the grove run straight and true, and Pook skips along to lead the heroes out himself.

The May fair goes ahead in a swirl of music and dancing, and **Danu the Kind** smiles down from above the green isles. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.